off, the rain stopped and we went ahead. Nicky Butt scored two and I got the other—a volley, left foot, from the edge of the box after Ben Thornley cut the ball back– and then we won 3–2 back at our place. The bond in that team was amazing, with Ryan Giggs, who was a year older than most of us, as captain.

That second leg at Old Trafford was a huge night: there were 32,000 United fans there to watch, which made for a bigger atmosphere than any of us had ever experienced before. You always get supporters who want to see the local talent come through and so follow the Youth side. But 32,000 of them? Maybe the word was getting round that the club had found a particularly good group of young players. I think we were aware of what was going on, but we never really talked about it amongst ourselves. Over the two or three years we were coming through, Alex Ferguson said just once: 'If we don't get a first-team player out of this lot, we might as well all pack up and go home.' Other than that, nobody inside the club mentioned that there might be something special happening. The focus was always on that day's training session or on that afternoon's game.

We got to the Youth Cup Final the following year, too. I can still remember the semi-final against Millwall. We'd heard that they had something planned before the game. Sure enough, out they came on the night of the first leg at Old Trafford, and every single player had his head shaved. I don't know if that was what threw us off our stride, but we lost 2–1. For the second leg we had to go down to their ground—which, being nearly full, had a pretty intimidating atmosphere even for a Youth game—and we won 2–0 to go through to the final, where we played Leeds United.

People have said since that it was strange how we had so many future first-team players in our side and yet hardly any of the Leeds boys came through. In those two games, though, they played very well and were really fired up. We lost 2–0 at Old Trafford and then went to Elland Road for the second leg. There, it wasn't just the players who were up for it. We'd had a 30,000 crowd again in Manchester. When they announced that Leeds' home crowd was even bigger on the night, you'd have thought a goal had been scored. Their fans really got behind them and they beat us again, this time 2–1.

We'd played a lot of games that season and I remember being very tired, but losing that final wasn't such a bad thing. For most of us, it was the first big disappointment of our soccer-playing lives and perhaps it made us stronger, having to experience it together. You want to make sure you don't feel that down again in the future. And you certainly don't ever want Eric